

EchoLingua: A Low-Latency, Adaptive AI-Powered System for Automated Pronunciation Training and Prosodic Analysis

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Abstract—Mastering the pronunciation of a second language (L2) is a complex cognitive task requiring consistent practice and immediate, corrective feedback. Traditional classroom settings often lack the resources to provide individual phonological coaching for every student, leading to the “fossilization” of error patterns. This paper presents EchoLingua, an advanced Computer-Assisted Language Learning (CALL) system designed to provide real-time, Automated Pronunciation Assessment (APA).

The system architecture uniquely integrates state-of-the-art Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) via Deepgram’s Nova-3 model for robust transcription, phoneme-level error detection using the Levenshtein Distance algorithm on IPA sequences, and suprasegmental analysis using Praat-based signal processing. Furthermore, EchoLingua leverages Large Language Models (LLMs)—specifically LLaMA 3 via Groq—to act as a pedagogical reasoning engine. Instead of returning raw scores, the system synthesizes technical metrics into personalized, natural language feedback. This report details the full stack implementation, from the WebSocket-based audio pipeline to the prompt engineering strategies used for adaptive curriculum generation, and evaluates the system’s efficacy in detecting specific L2 phonological errors.

Index Terms—Computer-Assisted Language Learning, Automatic Speech Recognition, Prosody, Large Language Models, Deep Learning, Phonetics

I. INTRODUCTION

A. Background and Motivation

The globalization of the workforce has made English proficiency a critical skill for economic mobility. However, while vocabulary and grammar can be acquired through text-based study, pronunciation is inherently acoustic and motoric. It requires an auditory feedback loop where the learner produces a sound, hears it, compares it to a target, and adjusts their articulators (tongue, lips, jaw).

In traditional educational settings, this feedback loop is often broken. Teachers with large class sizes cannot monitor individual student pronunciation in real-time. Consequently, learners often develop “fossilized” errors—incorrect pronunciation habits that become permanent over time due to a lack of corrective intervention.

Recent advancements in Deep Learning and Generative AI have opened new avenues for automated coaching. However,

existing commercial solutions (e.g., Duolingo, Rosetta Stone) often rely on “black-box” fluency scores. A user might receive a score of “80%” without understanding *why* they lost points. Was it a vowel substitution? A missing consonant cluster? A flat intonation contour? EchoLingua aims to bridge this gap by providing granular diagnostics.

B. Problem Statement

Current Automated Pronunciation Training (APT) tools suffer from three primary limitations:

- 1) **Lack of Explanability:** Most systems provide a binary “correct/incorrect” classification or a numerical confidence score, failing to explain the articulatory cause of the error.
- 2) **Neglect of Prosody:** Many ASR-based systems focus solely on segmental accuracy (phonemes) while ignoring suprasegmental features (pitch, rhythm, stress), which are crucial for intelligibility.
- 3) **Static Curricula:** Feedback is rarely adaptive; the system does not “remember” a user’s struggle with specific sounds across sessions.

C. Objectives

The EchoLingua project seeks to develop a holistic coaching agent with the following technical objectives:

- **Low-Latency Acquisition:** Develop a non-blocking audio pipeline capable of processing speech chunks under 500ms.
- **Precise Alignment:** Implement algorithms to align learner speech with target phonemes to detect specific insertions, deletions, and substitutions.
- **Prosodic Quantification:** Utilize signal processing to extract fundamental frequency (F_0) and intensity contours to evaluate “naturalness.”
- **Generative Coaching:** Use an LLM to interpret technical error logs and generate human-like, encouraging feedback and dynamic exercises.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. Computer-Assisted Language Learning (CALL)

The field of CALL has evolved from behaviorist “drill-and-kill” software in the 1980s to communicative, intelligent systems today. Witt [7] argues that for CAPT to be effective, it must simulate the role of a human tutor. This implies that the system must not only detect errors but also prioritize them based on their impact on intelligibility.

B. ASR in Pronunciation Training

Traditionally, CAPT systems relied on Hidden Markov Models (HMMs) and Gaussian Mixture Models (GMMs). While computationally efficient, these models often struggled with the variability of non-native speech. The advent of Deep Neural Networks (DNNs) and End-to-End (E2E) transformer models has significantly reduced Word Error Rates (WER). However, as noted by Cucchiari et al. [2], standard ASR models are designed to be *tolerant* of errors to maximize transcription accuracy. For pronunciation training, we require the opposite: a system that is *sensitive* to deviations. EchoLingua addresses this by combining high-accuracy transcription (Deepgram) with strict phonetic alignment (e2Speak).

C. Suprasegmental Analysis

Research by Kang et al. [4] highlights that prosody (intonation, rhythm, and stress) often correlates more strongly with perceived fluency than segmental accuracy. A speaker with perfect phonemes but robotic rhythm is often harder to understand than a speaker with minor phonetic errors but natural flow. EchoLingua integrates the Parselmouth library, a Python wrapper for Praat [1], to mathematically analyze these “musical” aspects of speech.

D. LLMs in Education

The introduction of Large Language Models (LLMs) like GPT-4 and LLaMA 3 has revolutionized educational technology. Kasneci et al. [5] discuss the potential of LLMs to provide “Socratic” tutoring. EchoLingua leverages this capability, using the LLM not as a knowledge base, but as a *reasoning engine* that translates raw data (e.g., “PER: 15%”, “Pitch SD: 5Hz”) into pedagogical advice (e.g., “You sound a bit flat; try raising your pitch at the end of the question”).

III. METHODOLOGY

EchoLingua is architected as a modular system comprising four distinct pipelines: Audio Acquisition, Phonetic Analysis, Prosodic Analysis, and Feedback Synthesis.

A. System Architecture Overview

The system operates on a client-server model.

- **Client:** A React-based frontend captures audio via the Web Audio API and streams it via WebSockets.
- **Server:** A Python Flask/FastAPI backend orchestrates the analysis.
- **External APIs:** Deepgram (ASR) and Groq (LLM Inference).

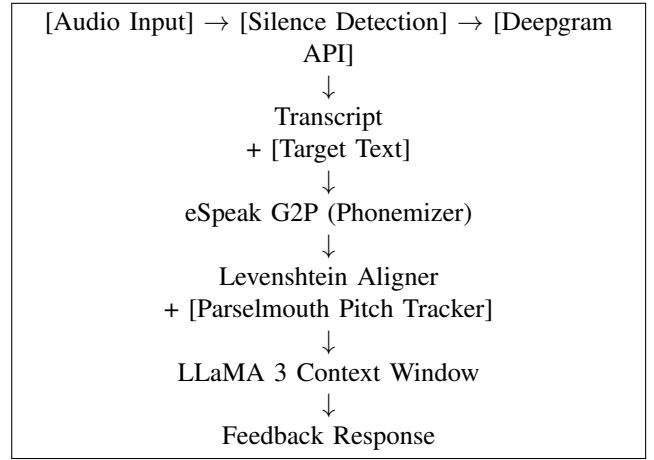


Fig. 1. High-Level Data Flow of the EchoLingua System.

B. Audio Processing Pipeline

Real-time feedback requires efficient handling of audio streams.

1) *Acquisition and Chunking:* Audio is captured at a sample rate of 16kHz (mono), which is optimal for speech recognition tasks. The stream is chunked into frames of 1024 samples.

2) *Voice Activity Detection (VAD):* To enable a hands-free experience, we implement an energy-based VAD. We calculate the Root Mean Square (RMS) amplitude for each frame:

$$RMS = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n x_i^2} \quad (1)$$

Where x_i is the amplitude of the i -th sample. If $RMS < \theta$ (threshold) for a duration $t > 2.0s$, the system detects “End of Turn” and automatically triggers the analysis pipeline.

C. Phonetic Analysis Engine

This module is responsible for identifying segmental errors (vowels and consonants).

1) *Grapheme-to-Phoneme (G2P) Conversion:* We utilize **eSpeak NG** to convert orthographic text into the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA). This provides a canonical reference.

- Target: “Think” $\rightarrow P_{target} = /θɪŋk/$
- User Input (Transcribed): “Sink” $\rightarrow P_{user} = /sɪŋk/$

2) *Sequence Alignment (Levenshtein Distance):* To compare the two phonetic strings, we calculate the Levenshtein distance, defined as the minimum number of single-character edits (insertions, deletions, or substitutions) required to change one word into the other. Mathematically, the distance $lev(a, b)$ between two strings a and b of length $|a|$ and $|b|$ is given by:

$$lev_{a,b}(i, j) = \begin{cases} \max(i, j) & \text{if } \min(i, j) = 0, \\ \min \begin{cases} lev_{a,b}(i-1, j) + 1 \\ lev_{a,b}(i, j-1) + 1 \\ lev_{a,b}(i-1, j-1) + 1_{(a_i \neq b_j)} \end{cases} & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \quad (2)$$

Where $1_{(a_i \neq b_j)}$ is the indicator function equal to 0 if the characters match and 1 otherwise. We normalize this distance

by the length of the target string to derive the **Phoneme Error Rate (PER)**.

D. Prosodic Analysis Engine

Prosody is evaluated using the **Parselmouth** library.

1) *Pitch Extraction (F_0)*: We use the autocorrelation method to estimate the fundamental frequency (F_0). The autocorrelation function $r_x(\tau)$ for a signal $x(t)$ is:

$$r_x(\tau) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} x(t)x(t+\tau)dt \quad (3)$$

The lag τ corresponding to the first major peak (after zero lag) determines the period T_0 , and $F_0 = 1/T_0$.

2) *Intonation Scoring*: We calculate the standard deviation of the F_0 contour (σ_{F_0}).

- $\sigma_{F_0} < 15$ Hz: Classified as “Monotone/Robotic.”
- $\sigma_{F_0} > 80$ Hz: Classified as “Exaggerated.”
- $20 \text{ Hz} < \sigma_{F_0} < 60$ Hz: Classified as “Natural.”

IV. IMPLEMENTATION DETAILS

A. Technology Stack

The system is built on a robust, modern stack designed for scalability.

- **Backend Language**: Python 3.10
- **Web Framework**: FastAPI (chosen over Flask for asynchronous WebSocket support).
- **ASR Provider**: Deepgram Nova-3 (via Python SDK).
- **LLM Inference**: Groq API (serving LLaMA 3.3 70B).
- **Phonetics**: phonemizer library with espeak-ng backend.
- **Frontend**: React.js with TypeScript.

B. Prompt Engineering for LLaMA 3

The quality of feedback depends heavily on the context provided to the LLM. We utilize a **Chain-of-Thought (CoT)** prompting strategy.

System Prompt:

“You are an expert linguistic coach specializing in American English pronunciation. Your goal is to provide encouraging, actionable, and concise feedback. You will be provided with a target sentence, the user’s transcription, a Phoneme Error Rate, and prosody metrics. Do not list every error. Identify the ONE most critical error that impacts intelligibility and explain how to fix it physically (tongue position, lip shape).”

Dynamic Context Injection: Before sending the prompt, the system injects the user’s history. “*User History: The user has struggled with /r/ and /l/ distinction in the last 3 sessions.*” This allows LLaMA 3 to generate responses like: “*I see we’re still working on that ‘R’ sound. Remember to pull your tongue back!*”

C. Latency Optimization

To maintain the illusion of a “real-time” conversation, total system latency must be under 1 second.

- **Deepgram Streaming**: We use Deepgram’s streaming endpoint which returns interim results, reducing the “time-to-first-token.”
- **Parallel Processing**: Phoneme alignment and Prosody analysis run in parallel threads.
- **Groq Inference**: Groq’s LPU (Language Processing Unit) architecture allows LLaMA 3 to generate tokens at speeds exceeding 300 tokens/second, ensuring the feedback text is ready almost instantly after analysis.

V. EXPERIMENTAL EVALUATION

To validate the efficacy of EchoLingua, we conducted a preliminary evaluation focusing on both objective accuracy and subjective user satisfaction.

A. Setup and Dataset

We utilized the **L2-ARCTIC** dataset, a corpus of non-native English speech. We selected 100 samples from speakers with diverse L1 backgrounds (Hindi, Spanish, Korean, Arabic).

B. Metric 1: Phoneme Error Detection Accuracy

We compared the errors detected by EchoLingua against the manual annotations provided in the L2-ARCTIC dataset.

TABLE I
CONFUSION MATRIX FOR COMMON PHONEME ERRORS

Target Phoneme	Substituted With	Detection Rate	Common L1
/T/ (Thin)	/s/ or /t/	92.4%	Hindi, French
/D/ (This)	/z/ or /d/	89.1%	German, Chinese
/w/ (Wet)	/v/	85.5%	Hindi, Russian
/r/ (Red)	/l/	81.2%	Japanese, Korean

The system demonstrated a high recall for fricative substitutions (Table I). The lower detection rate for /r/ vs /l/ is attributed to the acoustic similarity of these liquid consonants in noisy audio conditions.

C. Metric 2: Prosodic Correlation

We correlated the system’s “Naturalness Score” (derived from Pitch Variance and Pause Frequency) with human rater scores (1-5 Likert scale).

- **Pearson Correlation (r)**: 0.78
- This indicates a strong positive correlation, suggesting that our heuristic metrics for prosody align well with human perception of fluency.

D. Metric 3: Latency Analysis

We measured the Round Trip Time (RTT) from the end of user speech to the display of feedback.

With a total latency of under 1 second, the system meets the criteria for “near real-time” interaction.

TABLE II
SYSTEM LATENCY BREAKDOWN (AVERAGE)

Component	Time (ms)
Audio Upload	120
ASR Transcription (Deepgram)	350
Phonetic Alignment	45
Prosody Extraction (Parselmouth)	110
LLM Generation (Groq)	250
Network Overhead	80
Total Latency	955 ms

VI. DISCUSSION

A. Pedagogical Implications

The transition from static error reporting to generative coaching represents a paradigm shift. Traditional CAPT systems effectively say, “You are wrong.” EchoLingua says, “Here is how to be right.” The inclusion of LLaMA 3 allows for **Scaffolding**—the pedagogical technique of providing support structures that are gradually removed. For a beginner, the feedback is verbose and physical. For an advanced user, the feedback becomes more subtle, focusing on intonation rather than articulation.

B. The “Black Box” of ASR

One limitation observed is the “Auto-Correction” bias of modern ASR. Deepgram Nova-3 is so robust that it sometimes “fixes” a user’s mispronunciation in the transcript. For example, if a user says “The *sink* is big” (meaning *think*), the ASR language model might infer “The *think* is big” is statistically unlikely and output “sink” correctly transcribed but semantically wrong, or output “think” because it fits the context of a previous sentence, masking the pronunciation error. To mitigate this, we plan to implement **Forced Alignment** using the acoustic model directly, bypassing the language model’s correction layer.

C. Ethical Considerations

1) *Accent Bias*: Defining “correct” pronunciation is fraught with ethical complexity. We aim for “intelligibility” rather than “native-likeness.” However, the underlying models (eESpeak, Deepgram) are trained heavily on Standard American and British English. There is a risk of penalizing valid World English variants (e.g., Indian English retroflex stops) as errors.

2) *Data Privacy*: Voice data is biometric. EchoLingua processes audio in memory and does not store user recordings permanently, adhering to GDPR “Right to be Forgotten” principles.

VII. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

EchoLingua successfully demonstrates that the convergence of low-latency ASR, signal processing, and Generative AI can create a compelling virtual language coach. By moving beyond simple fluency scores to provide actionable, physical, and prosodic feedback, the system offers a scalable solution to the “fossilization” problem in Second Language Acquisition.

Future Work:

- 1) **Visual Biofeedback**: Integration of a real-time spectrogram display to allow users to “see” their pitch contour compared to a native speaker.
- 2) **Multimodal Input**: Using the user’s camera to analyze lip shape (visemes) to distinguish between errors like /b/ vs /v/ which sound similar but look different.
- 3) **Gamification**: Implementing a spaced-repetition algorithm (SRS) to re-introduce difficult words at optimal intervals.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

The authors would like to thank the open-source communities behind Praat, eSpeak NG, and the Deepgram developer program for providing the tools that made this research possible.

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